


# YOU HAD ME AT HELLO: LANGUAGE AS AN IDENTITY MARKER

**The Self & Social Identities**

# SAME PERSON, DIFFERENT LABEL

**Queer Person/LGBTQ+ Person**

**Illegal immigrant / Undocumented immigrant**

**Homeless person / Unhoused Person**

**Disabled person/ Person with a disability**

**Non-native English speaker / Multilingual speaker**

**Mixed / Half-White, half-Asian**

- What does each label make **salient**?
- Does either label imply something about **belonging, status, or "normality"**?
- Who typically gets to choose the label—the person, other people, or institutions?

# SOCIAL IDENTITY THEORY & LANGUAGE

- Much like SIT argues, language also marks group membership

- What are some examples of when you have noticed language, dialect or accent differences? And did you view those people as different or similar group members?



- When have you adapted your own speaking style and why did you do that?

# LANGUAGE POLICY IN THE U.S.

The U.S. Constitution does **not** name an official language.

March 2025, President Trump issued an executive order designating English as the official language of the United States.

Thirty states separately designate English as their official language.



# LANGUAGE AS AN IDENTITY MARKER

- "Social identity and ethnicity are in large part established and maintained through language" Gumperz & Cook-Gumperz




- <u>Codeswitching:</u>
  - Changing one's language or speaking style in line with the context

- SLA (second language acquisition) is difficult to fit into an SIT model-Why?

# LANGUAGE AS AN IDENTITY MARKER

- SIT doesn't account for the individual variation of language use
- SIT doesn't account for the multiple group memberships regarding language use
- But SIT still accounts for ingroup/outgroup distinctions regarding language




- Language is truly dynamic—so it is a marker of identity or an identity itself?

# DEJESUS STUDY: NORTHERN VS. SOUTHERN ACCENTS

- We judge each other based on our language, grammar, and accent
- Y'all—what are your instant reactions to that word?
- Accents and speaking style bias interview outcomes, home rentals and purchases, friend and spouse selection, etc.

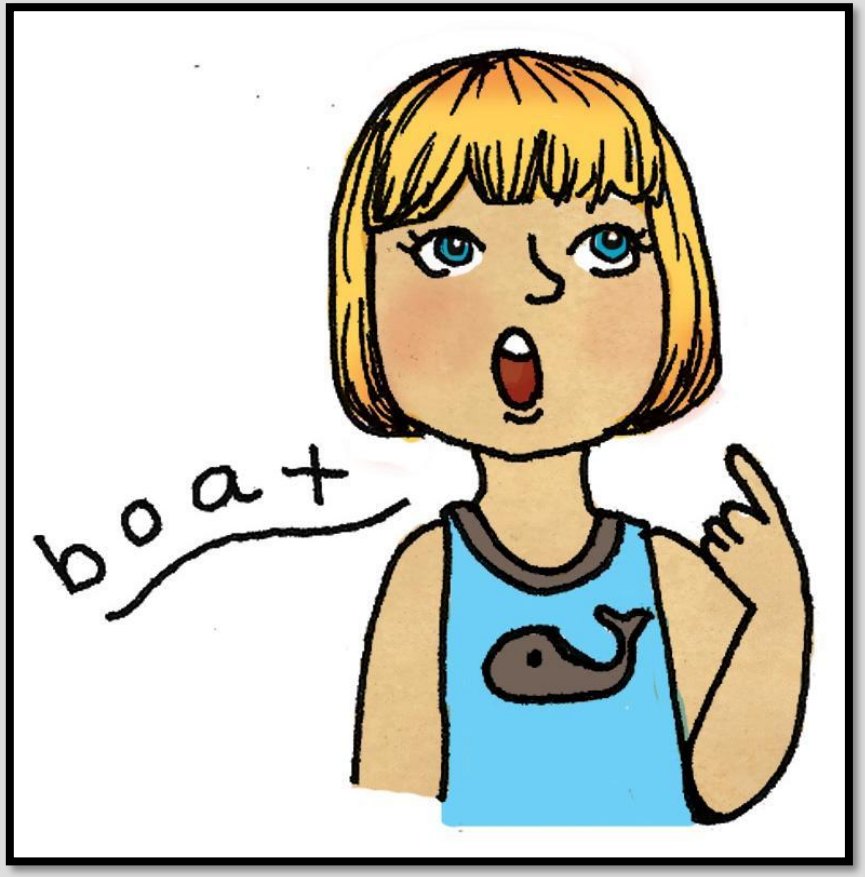


# NORTHERN VS. SOUTHERN ACCENTS

- Adults from the Northern U.S. reliably rank the South where people speak the "worst English" (Preston, 1993, 1998)

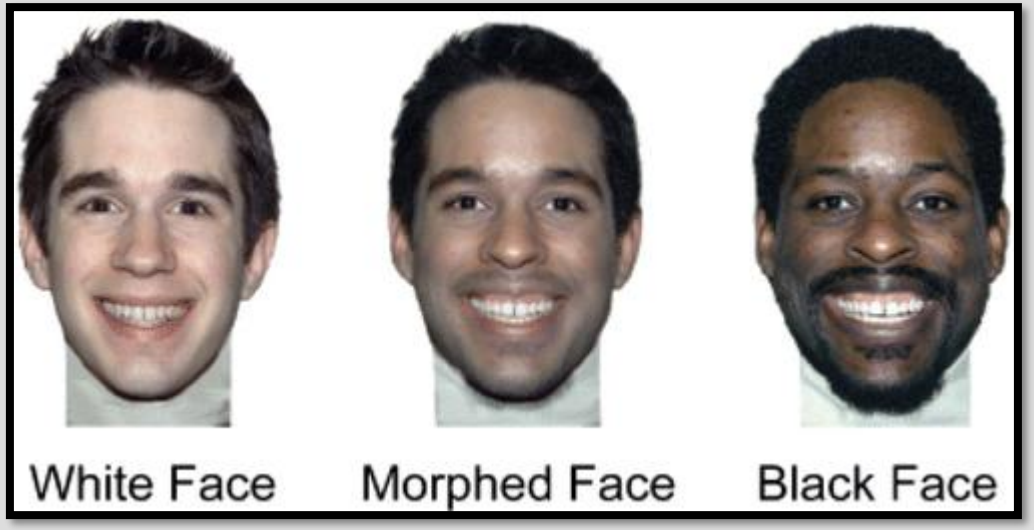
- Adults from the Southern U.S. rate their own region as relatively low in correctness, but they rate Southern speech positively

- <u>Research Question:</u>
  - Are children aware of these same stereotypes and show differing preferences?



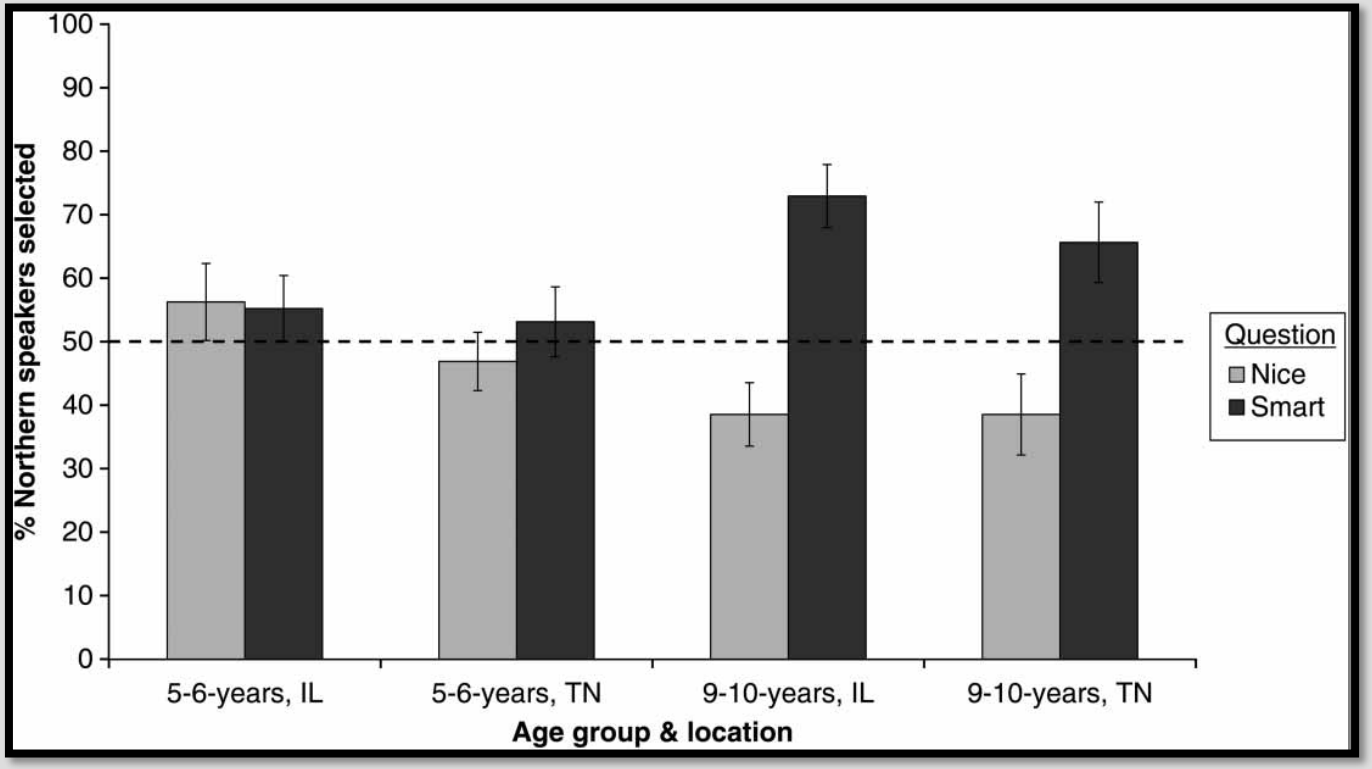
# NORTHERN VS. SOUTHERN ACCENTS: METHOD & RESULTS

- Experiment 1: Children from Illinois and Tennessee (ages 5-6) recruited
  - Voice clips of northern and southern accents played with adult faces and children provided preferences
  - Results:
    - Northern children showed preferences for northern accents, but southern children were at chance levels (no preference)



# NORTHERN VS. SOUTHERN ACCENTS: METHOD & RESULTS

- Experiment 2: Children from Illinois and Tennessee (ages 9-10) recruited, same methods

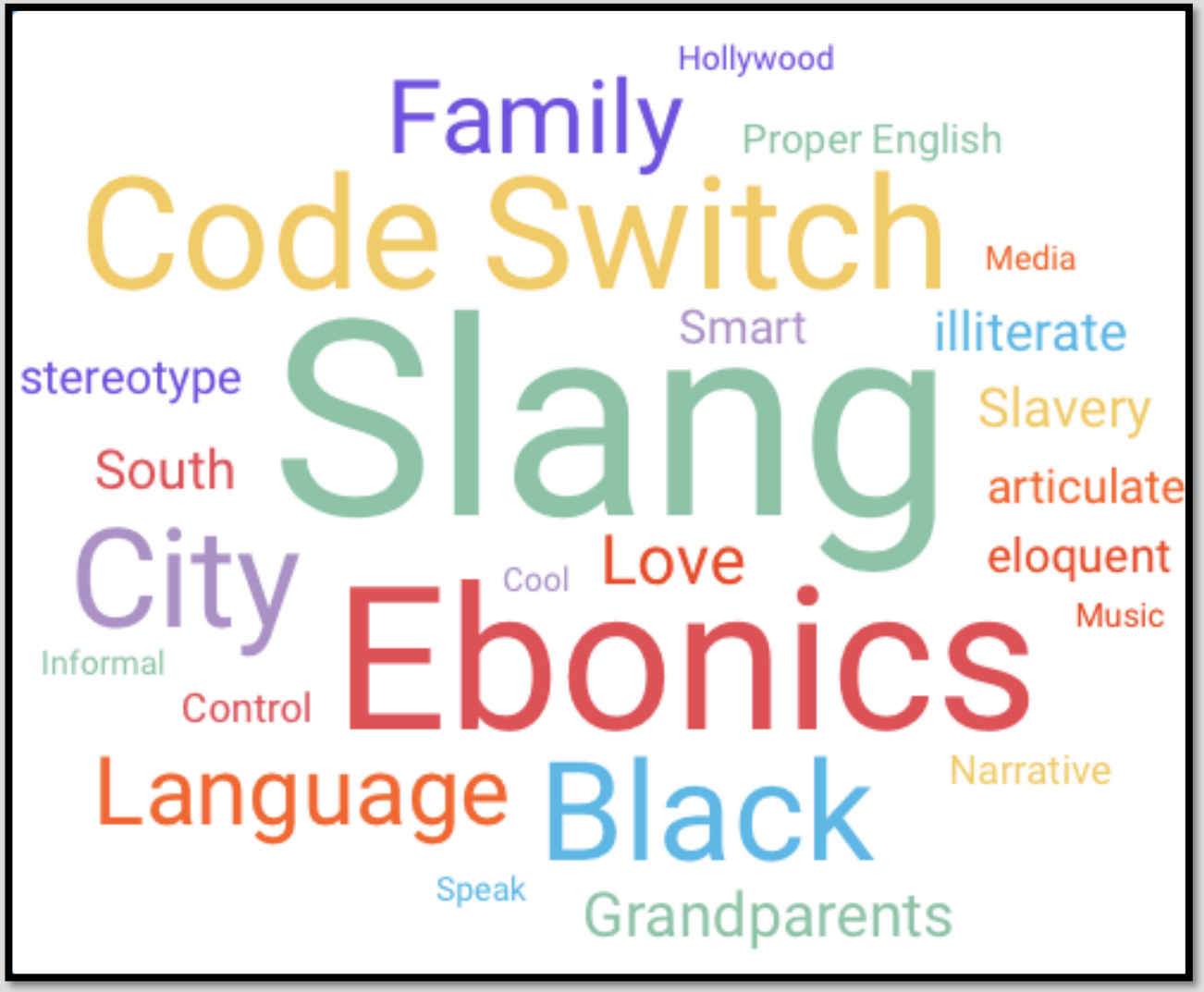



- Results:
  - Now both Northern and Southern children show learned stereotypes of northerners as smarter and more in charge and southerners as nicer

# DIALECT VARIATION…OR?

**Language of Home**





- If language shapes how we think, how might it also shape how we think about ourselves and our social identities?
- How does changing our language shift our behavior, attitudes, and perspectives?
- What features/aspects of life does language cause us to see/not see?





# WHAT IS BEING 'BILINGUAL'?

**'A scientific definition is hard to pin down'**

Nativelikeness? Equal fluency?

Two monolinguals in one?

Equal competence not always possible

Code-switching

Primary versus secondary language

Different languages for different contexts




# BILINGUAL BABIES

## Raising a bilingual child: The top 5 myths

Growing up with more than one language confuses children.

Raising a child to be bilingual leads to speech delays.

Bilingual children end up mixing the two languages.

It's too late to raise your child bilingual.

Children are like sponges, and they'll become bilingual without effort and in no time.

# BILINGUAL BABIES: MYTHS UNCOVERED

**1. Growing up with more than one language confuses children.**

*Evidence*: Bosch & Sebastián-Gallés, 1997

*Question*: Can bilingual babies discriminate their two languages?

*Experiment*: Compare monolingual and bilingual babies' ability to discriminate between languages at four months of age

*Hypothesis*: bilingual babies will be able to discriminate between their two languages

# GROWING UP WITH MORE THAN ONE LANGUAGE CONFUSES CHILDREN?

- Experiment 1: Do **monolingual infants** show a preference for their native language at 4 months of age?

- Spanish- and Catalan-learning infants, tested on English vs. Spanish/Catalan stimuli

- Faster reaction times in native language condition (Spanish/Catalan) compared with non-native language (English)

|  |  |  |
|---|---|---|
| Good Morning | Buenos días | Bon dia |
| Good Bye | Adiós | Adeu |
| Thank you | Gracias | Gracies |
| Come on | Vamos | Anem |
| Please | Por favor | si us plau |
| What are you doing? | Que haces? | Que fas? |
| Exit | Salida | Sortida |
| Left / Right | Izquierda / Derecha | esquerra / dreta |
| Next station | Próxima parada | Propera Parada |
| Drink | Bebida | Beguda |
| Water | Agua | Aigua |

# GROWING UP WITH MORE THAN ONE LANGUAGE CONFUSES CHILDREN?

- Experiments 4a-b: Can **bilingual infants** discriminate between languages at 4 months of age?

- Spanish/Catalan bilingual infants, tested on English vs. Spanish/Catalan stimuli AND on Spanish vs. Catalan stimuli

- Bilinguals were slower to respond overall, but were faster to respond to non-native (English) stimuli than to Spanish/Catalan stimuli

|  |  |  |
|---|---|---|
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# BILINGUAL MYTHS UNCOVERED

1. **Growing up with more than one language confuses children.**

**Not necessarily a myth**

2. Raising a child to be bilingual leads to speech delays.

3. Bilingual children end up mixing the two languages.

# BILINGUAL BABIES: MYTHS UNCOVERED

**2. Raising a child to be bilingual leads to speech delays.**

*Evidence*: Fennell et al., 2007

*Question*: How easily can bilinguals learn new words?

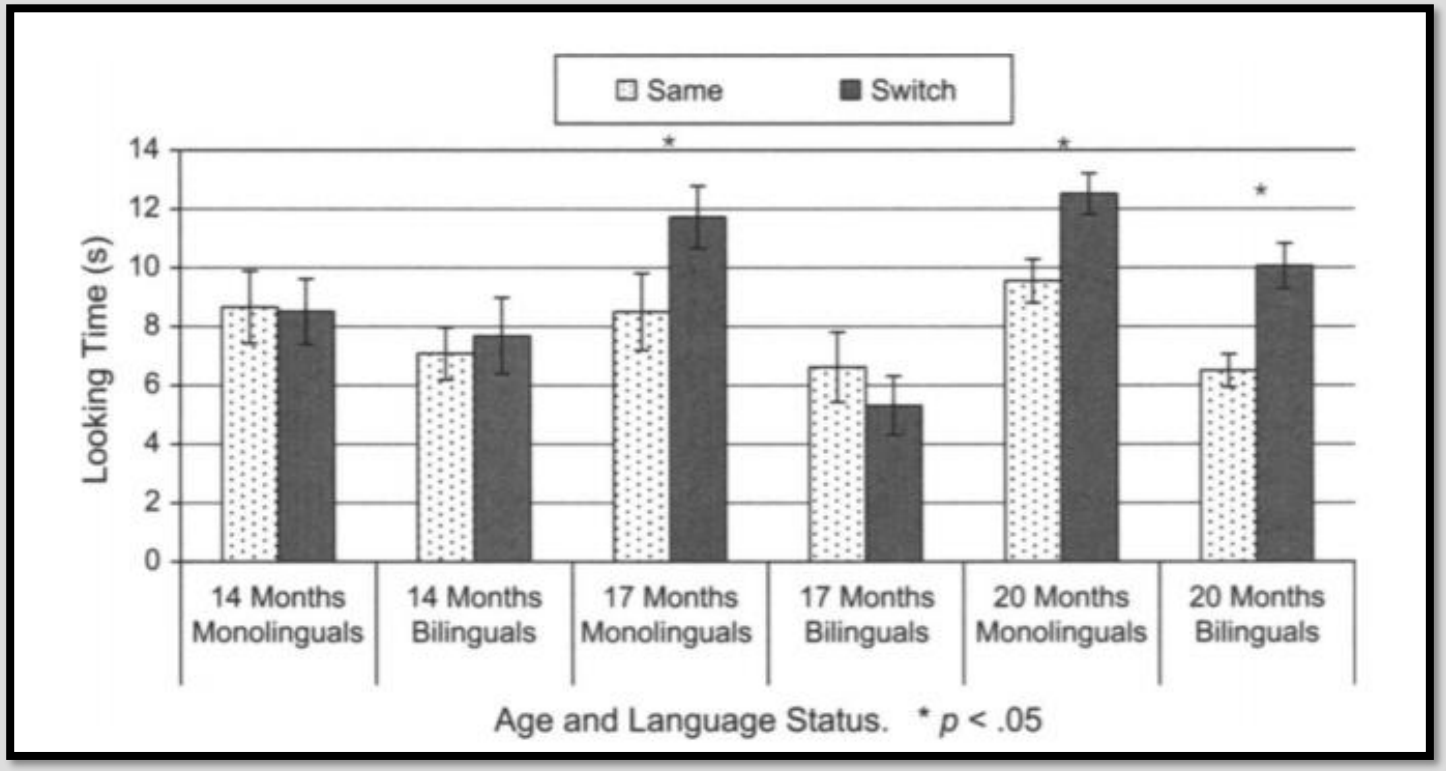
*Experiment*: Compare monolingual and bilingual babies' ability to learn novel words that are phonologically very similar

*Hypothesis*: the increased cognitive load of learning two languages will make this task more difficult for bilinguals – 'resource limitation hypothesis' Stager & Werker, 1997

# RAISING A CHILD TO BE BILINGUAL LEADS TO SPEECH DELAYS?

- Bilingual infants ages 14-20 months, compared with monolingual infants from a previous experiment (Werker et al., 2002)

- Bilinguals are slower to detect differences between novel words than monolinguals, suggesting a disadvantage in early word learning.



# BILINGUAL MYTHS UNCOVERED

1. **Growing up with more than one language confuses children.**

**Not necessarily a myth**

2. **Raising a child to be bilingual leads to speech delays.**

**Not necessarily a myth**

3. Bilingual children end up mixing the two languages.

# BILINGUAL BABIES: MYTHS UNCOVERED

**3. Bilingual children end up mixing the two languages.**

*Evidence*: Petitto et al., 2001

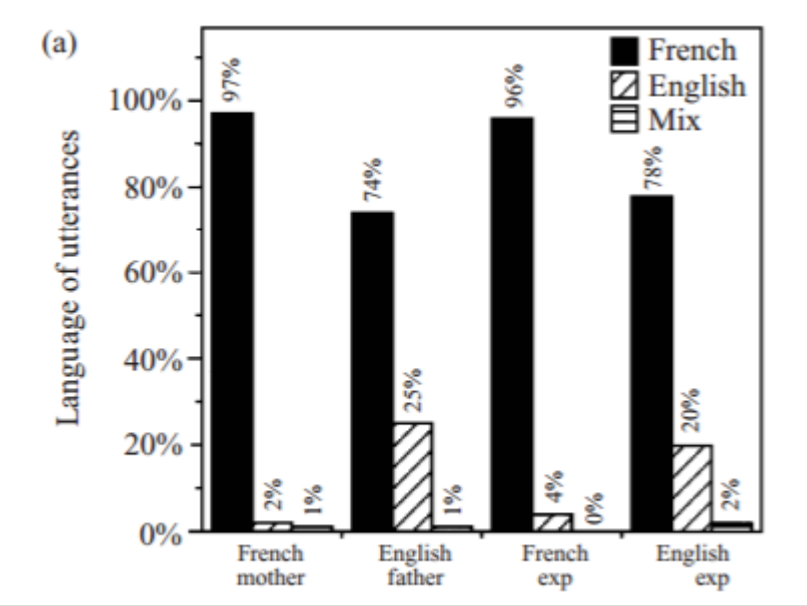
*Question*: How do bilinguals use their two languages?

*Experiment*: Compare French-English bilinguals' interactions with caregivers and experimenters in videotaped sessions, with both natural and prompted language use.

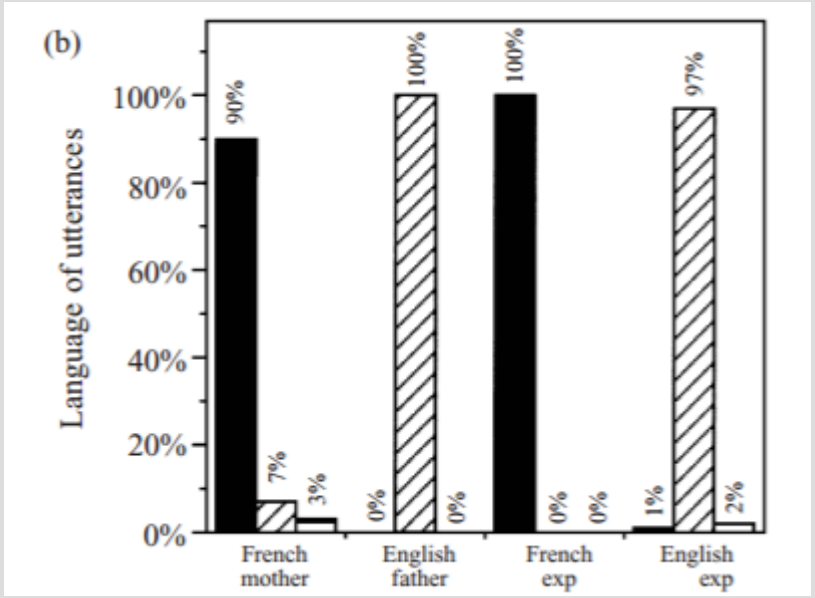
*Hypothesis*: Infants should not be sensitive to language context early on (→ more mixing) but should become more sensitive over time (→ less mixing)

# BILINGUAL CHILDREN END UP MIXING THE TWO LANGUAGES?

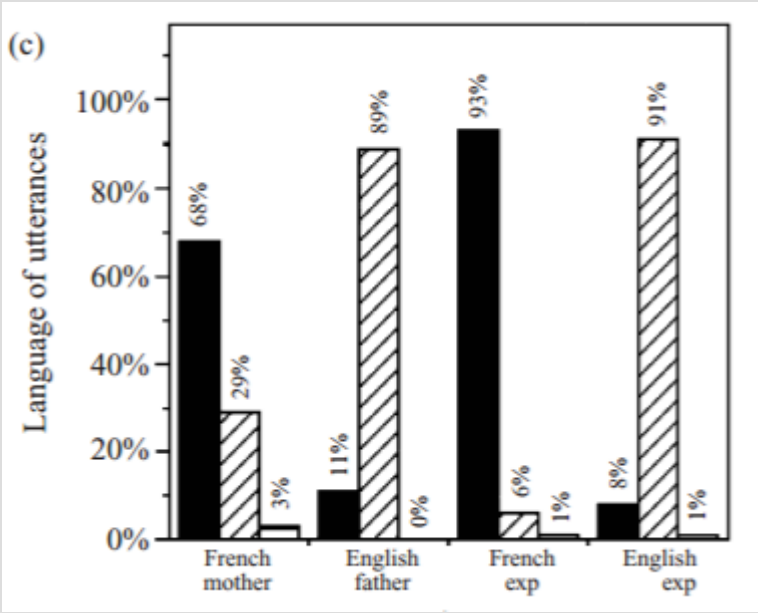
- Over time, the children became increasingly aware of the language being spoken → less language mixing over time




Time 1




Time 2




Time 3

# BILINGUAL MYTHS UNCOVERED

1. **Growing up with more than one language confuses children.** — **Not necessarily a myth**
2. **Raising a child to be bilingual leads to speech delays.** — **Not necessarily a myth**
3. **Bilingual children end up mixing the two languages.** — **Not necessarily a myth**

# IS BEING A BILINGUAL BABY A PROBLEM? **NO!**

- Bilingual adults have better working memory (Bialystok et al., 2004)
- Bilingualism slows down age-related cognitive decline (Bialystok et al., 2004)
- Bilingual 4-5 year olds are better at problem solving and better attentional control (Bialystok et al., 1999)




→ **Language development may be slower in early life, but there are clear intellectual advantages that persist**



# DISCUSSION TIME

- With children viewing their own language group in both positive and negative ways, how do these papers link with intergroup conflict and self-enhancement theory? Especially being multilingual?

- How do these results or language use more broadly relate to one's need to belong? What about the first vs. second language learned?

# NEXT CLASS….

- **NO CLASS THURSDAY!!**
- **Online Interactive Lecture on Intercultural Relationships Due by 10pm Thursday Night Instead!**
- **Next Week: Discussion Posts Due Monday 2pm, Paper 2 Discussed**
- **Testing Center—sign up for midterm Oct 22!**

